operations on November 1, 1906, from its registered office at Oriental Building, Esplanade Road (now the office of the American Express Bank).[1]

The Bank of India was not the first bank to use this name but it was the first to survive and subsequently thrive. The first was started in 1828 in Calcutta; the second as an ‘Anglo-Indian Bank’ in London in 1836; and the third in Bombay in 1864. None of these banks were in existence when Sir Sassoon established his Bank of India. His last words as reported by Sir Cowasji Jehangir 2nd Baronet, were, ‘Take care of the Bank of India.’[2]

The setting up of the Bank of India proved to be the inflection point in Sorabji’s career. We have already noted how Sorabji’s natural curiosity and substantial ambition had made him go beyond the confines of his job. He attempted to learn the entire process of banking rather than restrict himself to only his very limited role. He had set his sights higher than most and given the prevailing prejudice must have realized that the best he could do was to become head clerk like his brother, a prospect which must have appealed little to the ambitious young man. Sorabji decided that the setting up of the Bank of India was just the springboard to the accelerated advancement he desired. He used the good offices of his friends D.L. Panday and Homi C. Sethna to get Phiroze Sethna (who would later become the Chairman of the Central Bank and earn a knighthood), to introduce him to Sir Shapurji Broacha. The desired meeting materialized but Sir Shapurji’s response was hardly promising. ‘Son’, he said, ‘I suggest you apply again after a few years when you will have grown more whiskers. This post is for a more experienced person’.[3] If racial prejudice had blocked his path with the English banks, it was his youth and a perceived lack of experience which barred his way at the Bank of India.

A lesser man may have admitted defeat but Sorabji in his second sally managed to persuade Sir Shapurji to take him to see Sir Sassoon. So keen was Sorabji in getting the requisite experience that he suggested that he be allowed to work without a salary. The eager young man created a favourable impression on Sir Sassoon who asked him what salary he expected. Sorabji requested for ₹200 but was offered ₹I50 in the post of a sub-accountant, an offer which he promptly accepted. For Sorabji the monetary compensation was secondary; he was more interested in the designation and the opportunities that went with the higher status. Even the